# Covered, Not Removed

Soft Moderation, Attention and the Norms of
Political Incivility in Short-Video Feeds

*Speaker notes for the study pitch*

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**Abstract**

Ten-minute pitch: 9 content slides (target about 9:20, hard stop 10:00), a Q&A slide and a backup methods slide. Each section gives the slide's time budget with a running clock, what is on screen, the script, the points to say even when cutting words, and the transition to the next slide. Citations in *[square brackets]* are notes for the speaker and are not read aloud.

**Panel:** Prof. Yannis Theocharis, Prof. Spyros Kosmidis and one postdoctoral researcher.

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## Slide 1: Title (0:35 · ends 0:35)

**On screen:** title; hook "When platforms label or hide uncivil political videos, do people look away or look closer?"

**Script**

> Thank you for having me. Imagine you are scrolling TikTok and a political video appears blurred: "This video may contain hostile language. Tap to view." Do you tap? Platforms increasingly govern political speech this way, not by deleting it but by governing what we see. So my question is: when platforms label or hide uncivil political videos, do people look away or look closer? And because these decisions shape what millions of citizens see of politics, this is a question about democratic discourse.

**Must say:** the scene (blurred video, "Tap to view", do you tap?) · governing what we see · look away or look closer · democratic discourse

**Transition:** "This is what that looks like."

## Slide 2: What citizens see (0:20 · ends 0:55)

**On screen:** three phones: label · interstitial cover · removal placeholder

**Script**

> This is what that looks like. The same uncivil political video can be labelled, covered so that you have to tap to see it, or replaced by a removal notice. These are exactly the three interventions in my study.

**Must say:** same video, three interventions · these are my treatments

**Transition:** "Why is this a puzzle?"

## Slide 3: The puzzle (1:00 · ends 1:55)

**On screen:** "The setting" and "What we know" boxes; two question boxes below

**Script**

> Moderation has shifted from deletion to visibility, and the DSA treats these restrictions as decisions that need reasons *[DSA Art. 17(1)]*. This happens in short-video feeds, where many young citizens now meet politics, and where incivility is often packaged as entertainment *[the Lab's ToxicAInment project]*. Incivility can even raise positive emotions among those who agree with it *[Kosmidis & Theocharis 2020, POQ, https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfaa014]*. We know that labels on false news work and do not backfire *[Martel & Rand 2024, Nat. Hum. Behav.]*, and that labelling some false headlines makes the rest look more accurate *[Pennycook et al. 2020, Mgmt Sci]*. But we know very little about soft moderation of uncivil

> political content. So my question has two parts. First, does it work, or does it backfire: do people engage less, as intended, or more, out of curiosity or because they see censorship of their side? Second, what does it signal: by flagging some videos and leaving others alone, does the platform tell viewers where the line is, so that unflagged uncivil content starts to look acceptable?

**Must say:** deletion → visibility · incivility as entertainment · labels on false news work · two questions (boxes on screen)

**Transition:** "Four mechanisms make competing predictions."

## Slide 4: Theory (1:45 · ends 3:40)

**On screen:** four-column table ("Implied acceptability*" marked as the new mechanism); "Democratic stake" box

**Script**

> I set four mechanisms against each other. First, signalling and compliance: an intervention signals harm and people defer, so engagement falls *[Martel & Rand 2024]*. Second, reactance: restricting access raises the value of what is restricted, so covers should increase tap-through, especially among people with strong free speech values *[Brehm 1966]*. Third, and this is my main theoretical move, norm signalling. Moderation communicates norms *[Cialdini et al. 1990; Munger 2016]*, so if some uncivil clips are covered, the uncovered ones may look sanctioned. I call this "implied acceptability", extending the implied truth effect from facts to civility norms *[Pennycook et al. 2020]*. Fourth, partisan identity, which connects to my DPhil work on how identities are reinforced in social spaces. Out-party incivility is entertaining to co-partisans *[Kosmidis & Theocharis 2020]*, so moderating it may read as partisan censorship.
>
> Why does this matter for democracy? As your own Scientific Reports paper puts it: "With over 4 billion people using social media platforms daily, decisions about what content to allow or moderate have profound implications for global public discourse, democratic deliberation, and users' psychological well-being." *[Theocharis, Kosmidis, Zilinsky & Quint 2026, Sci. Rep. 16, 19034]* And attention and civility norms are the infrastructure of democratic discussion *[Papacharissi 2004; Mutz 2015]*. If soft moderation amplifies what it hides, normalises what it misses, and is read as partisan, it could damage the discourse it is meant to protect.

**Must say:** four mechanisms · "implied acceptability" (my move) · DPhil identity link · Sci. Rep. quote · amplifies / normalises / partisan

**Transition:** "How do I separate these mechanisms?"

## Slide 5: Design (1:25 · ends 5:05)

**On screen:** bullets and "Within moderated feeds" box (left); four arms (right)

**Script**

> The design is a preregistered behavioural experiment in a mock vertical-video feed. I would build the feed myself as a custom web app, which is what I do in industry, or use an existing open research tool such as Yourfeed as an off-the-shelf option *[Epstein & Lin 2022, arXiv:2207.07478]*. Participants are short-video users in Germany first, then the UK and US. They scroll about thirty clips while the app logs swipes, dwell time, cover tap-throughs, likes, shares and follows. Between subjects, I randomise the feed regime: no moderation, or one of the three interventions from the phone mock-ups: a label, an interstitial cover, or a removal placeholder. Within the moderated feeds, only a random half of the uncivil clips are treated, re-randomised for each participant. This separates content from intervention, because the same clip is treated for some people and not others. It also fixes the main weakness of my earlier scrolling design, where curated content and treatment were confounded. I deliberately keep it to four arms. Whether an AI or a human made the decision is a separate question and a natural extension arm, but adding it now would cost power and blur the mechanism.

**Must say:** preregistered · I build the feed (custom web app, or Yourfeed) · the three interventions from the phones plus control · random half, re-randomised per person · content not confounded

**Transition:** "What do participants see, and what do I measure?"

## Slide 6: Stimuli and outcomes (1:00 · ends 6:05)

**On screen:** Stimuli box (left); Outcomes: behaviour / after the feed / before (right)

**Script**

> The stimuli are borderline uncivil political clips, half attacking each camp, plus civil political clips and entertainment fillers. One potential source is public PoliTok-DE material *[Ruiz et al. 2026, arXiv:2509.15860]*; all clips would be pre-rated with the Lab's toxicity typology *[Pradel et al. 2024, APSR: incivility / intolerance / violent threats]*. The primary outcomes are behavioural: dwell time, skips, tap-through, likes, shares, follows, and spillover to the untreated uncivil clips. After the feed I measure perceived norms, both how common and how acceptable this content is, perceived platform bias, and support for moderation using the Lab's free speech versus harm item *[Theocharis et al. 2026, Sci. Rep.]*, for comparability with CONTENT WARNING *[Theocharis et al. 2025, OSF report]*.

**Must say:** half attacking each camp · PoliTok-DE as a potential source · behaviour first · free speech vs. harm item

**Transition:** "The part I am most excited about is the spillover."

## Slide 7: Implied acceptability (1:00 · ends 7:05)

**On screen:** two feeds with clips C1 to C4 (grey = treated); dashed frame around C3 "same clip, compared"; legend; one takeaway line; "Analysis and ethics" box at the bottom

**Script**

> The design element I am most excited about is the spillover. Take an uncivil clip that is not treated. I compare engagement with that same clip, and how acceptable people rate it, between the moderated feeds and the unmoderated feed. If it gains engagement and acceptability when other clips are moderated, that is implied acceptability: moderation governs what it leaves untouched. Formally, this is a randomised saturation design, so I can separate three effects: the spillover on untreated clips, the direct effect of treatment, and the total effect *[Hudgens & Halloran 2008, JASA; Baird et al. 2018, REStat]*. I estimate them with clip fixed effects and standard errors clustered by participant, with mixed models as a robustness check, and I power the study on the spillover, because it is the hardest contrast. Ethically, the content is mild and public, with content notes, a skip option, and a full debrief that the labels were assigned at random.

**Must say:** same untreated clip across arms · governs what it leaves untouched · randomised saturation design: spillover, direct, total · power on the spillover · ethics in one sentence

**Transition:** "That gives four hypotheses."

## Slide 8: Hypotheses and implications (1:15 · ends 8:20)

**On screen:** four-row table: mechanism · hypothesis · if supported

**Script**

> This gives one hypothesis per mechanism. First, compliance: treated clips get less engagement than the same clips in the control feed. Second, reactance, which is the competing prediction for the same effect: covers get more tap-through and engagement, especially among people with strong free speech values. Third, implied acceptability: untreated uncivil clips gain engagement and acceptability in moderated feeds. Fourth, partisan bias: when the platform moderates clips that attack a viewer's opponents, that viewer sees the platform as biased against their side. Every result is informative. If compliance holds, soft moderation works without deleting speech. If covers backfire, "tap to view" amplifies what it hides, and labels are the better tool. If implied acceptability holds, consistency and coverage matter more than the strength of any single intervention. And if the backfire is partisan, transparency about the rules becomes a democratic necessity.

**Must say:** one hypothesis per mechanism · H1 and H2 compete · every result is informative

**Transition:** "To sum up."

## Slide 9: Contribution and fit (1:00 · ends 9:20)

**On screen:** Theory / Behaviour / Policy (left); "Lab fit and next steps" (right); closing line at the bottom

**Script**

> The contribution is a theory of moderation as norm signalling, to my knowledge the first causal behavioural evidence on soft moderation of uncivil political short video, and practical evidence for platform design under the DSA. It builds directly on ToxicAInment and could use PoliTok-DE material as stimuli, and it would give the Lab a reusable open mock feed for future experiments, including on whether it matters if an AI or a human made the decision. So, look away or look closer? The answer tells us whether soft moderation protects democratic discourse or quietly reshapes it. Thank you; I look forward to your questions.

**Must say:** theory · behaviour · policy · "to my knowledge" · ToxicAInment and PoliTok-DE · reusable feed · closing line

**Close:** "Thank you; I look forward to your questions." → click to the Thank you slide (slide 10) and leave it up.

## Slide 10: Thank you · Q&A (stays up during questions)

No script. Leave the slide up while they ask questions.

## Backup: Methods appendix (slide 11, only if asked)

**When to show it:** questions on identification, interference, estimation or power. Say: "I have a methods slide for that."

**Key points**

- **Why not just compare treated and untreated clips?** In a moderated feed the untreated clips are themselves exposed to the spillover, so that contrast is the direct effect *minus* the spillover. The control feed gives the clean baseline: spillover = untreated clips vs. control; total = treated vs. control; direct = total minus spillover.
- **Model:** one regression with clip fixed effects and separate indicators for treated and untreated clips in each feed type; position in the feed as a control. OLS (linear probability model for binary outcomes, log dwell time), SEs clustered by participant. Mixed models with crossed random intercepts as robustness.
- **Acceptability:** after the feed, participants re-rate a subset of clips, both treated and untreated.
- **Power:** simulation on pilot variance, powered on the between-arm spillover.
- **Extension:** vary saturation (25% vs. 75%) to test whether implied acceptability grows with how much is moderated.

## Before the call

- ☐ Read aloud once with a timer; check you are at about 5:05 after the design slide and 8:20 after the hypotheses
- ☐ PDF open in full-screen; backup PDF on desktop
- ☐ Teams: screen share test, camera, audio
- ☐ Water; this file printed or on a second screen

## References

Everything cited on the slides or in the [bracketed] notes. All entries verified online on 28 Oct 2026 (bibliographic records; full texts not read).

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Project: ToxicAInment (bidt; PIs Rieger, Schwemmer, Theocharis): https://www.hfp.tum.de/digitalgovernance/forschung-publikationen/forschungsprojekte/toxicainment/